Yellow Bus

By Leslie Epstein

INTRODUCTION

"Those who cannot remember the past are condemned to repeat it." With fewer living Holocaust survivors who can serve as eyewitnesses to the genocide and with a new wave of anti-Semitism in the US and Europe . . . will the past be forgotten?

In a 2020 nationwide survey studying Holocaust knowledge among millennials and Generation Z, 63% of adults under 40 did **not** know that 6 million Jews were murdered in the Holocaust. In fact, 1 in 10 reported **never** having heard the word ***Holocaust***. What's more . . . Over 40,000 concentration camps and ghettos were established during World War II, but nearly half of US respondents could not name a single one. (shakes head, takes a deep break and begins)

The year is 1941: Nisel Lipiczany is a boy of, let us say, 14. The Jewish Ghetto in Lodz, Poland is being liquidated by Nazi forces. Jews are being relocated by trainloads to "work the farms." Nisel manages to escape and follows the train track for days. But when he arrives at the train's final destination, he doesn't see a farm . . . just a Yellow Bus by Leslie Epstein.

NISEL: **(Pg 57-62)** I arrived late in the night. The tracks curved off side by side into a forest. The rails gleamed like the path left by a pair of giant snails. And there was the moon, sitting in the branches like a bright, fat owl. I plunged in.

But soon the trees stopped. Cut down. A sound, a groaning, a creaking. It came from a building, a big one, made from wood. All around it were the Death's-Headers. They were sitting and smoking and walking this way, that way, this way. The moonlight moved on their helmets.

Dawn! Now I could see everything in the clearing. The mill had three stories and a water wheel at one end. Turning and turning. I could see how the black buckets rose out of and sank into the roof. This was the noise, the creaking, I heard in the night. I lay pressed to the ground. They sky above was full of dark, low clouds, like sacks of something about to burst. What was this place? Why were the windows of the mill

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boarded up? What – could someone tell me what – was it grainding? Then a Warrior – he pulled on gloves, white ones, lifted the bar on the door and some of the Jews came out.

There were thirty of them all together. They carried their bundles. They still had their stars on their coats. They stood about in their black coats, their black hats. The Death's-Headers were standing too, or leaning against the side of an old yellow bus.

I could see the old-fashioned round headlights, one cracked, the other without a lens at all. The wings of the hood were lifted and a Warrior was lying over the fender, at work on the engine inside. The yellow roof – it was battered, dented, as if it had been stoned.

The band of Jews moved closer to the rear of the bus. They were all from our courtyard: Palfinger, a jeweler, two of the Fiebig sons, the Widow Greenkraut. I thought: Here they are, the plowers, the milkmaids, the ones who will pluck up the eggs. This is the bus that will take them all the way to the farm.

Then one of the Lords and Masters said something to them. Right away the Jews put down their sacks and valises and began to take off their clothes. Everything All of it. Even the undergarments. And they tied their shoes together by the laces. The back door of the bus swung open, the thirty Jews climbed inside, and the door slammed shut once more.

The mechanic slid from the fender, clapped – like this! – his hands together, and turned the crank. The engine started. The bus body shook. Drive off! Drive away! Drive to the farm! But the old bus did not move from the spot.

Only then, then, did I notice two things: first, the front wheels were missing, and second, there was no driver on the seat inside. Yet the engine roars, the body shakes, it sways. Minutes went by, one like another. A dark bird, dark like a crow, floated

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downward from the sky. It perched on top of Madame Dickstein's white bundle. The motor ran for a quarter of an hour. But it was the bird that scared me.

Then the engine stopped. A Man of Valor – the same one with the gloves, the one from the mill: he walked to the side of the bus and put his ear against it. ***Just like in a synagogue.*** That's what he said. They took the Jews out of the bus. All of them . . . . were sleeping.

Horses now. They were pulling a rubber-wheeled cart. In this cart the Jews were driven away – Up the riverbed. Out of sight. The piles of clothing, the luggage, the shoes – that remained behind.

And now, one after the other came fresh groups of Jews. The bus shuddered as usual, and then the sleepers were brought out again… again… again. Finally, at dusk, the rubber-wheeled cart picked up the mountain of clothing. The Warriors walked beside it to the mill.

Night fell. No stars. No moon. It was as dark as it is when I have my eyes shut. I walked into the riverbed. After a while, not long, a few minutes, I came to where the Jews were lying. Too dark to see their faces. Impossible to tell if my mother or father were there. I said, ***Wake up! Wake up, Jews! Let's go back to the ghetto! I know the way!*** But they didn't wake up. It was I who fell asleep beside them instead.

In the morning my mind was clear. Sane. Rational. Before I opened my eyes, I knew I would be surrounded by corpses. And there – there they were. With excrement on their legs. And some of the women stained with their own blood. I heard a sound. Soft. Nice almost. ***Shhhhh. Shhhhhh.*** Like someone with his finger on his lips. ***Shhhhh.*** Two men were walking among the bodies. Bending like farmers with scythes. They cut off the locks of the dead people's hair.

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What else to do but jump up and run? Run! Up the riverbank, through the clearing, into the forest. Then south, always south, not once stopping – until I came to where I thought there would be Jews. *(a brief pause: then)* Isn't it true? Aren't you? Look at me, dear people! All of you people! Are you awake? Are you alive? Are you Jews? *(pause)*

CLOSING

According to the International School for Holocaust Studies, the Nazis first experimented with gas vans in 1940 – they locked mentally ill children inside a sealed van and choked them to death with carbon monoxide. When the extermination of the Jewish population began in 1941, victims were shot to death. However, this was not a quick or secret enough method. The Reich shifted to using gas vans for murder on a larger scale. Ultimately the vans could not handle the sheer number of Jews that the Nazis planned to exterminate.

Remember that study I told you about? There was one last question: Do you believe something like the Holocaust could happen again? More than half of Americans say yes. . .

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Leslie Epstein
Book: Boston Theater Marathon 1 (Pg 57-62)
ISBN: 978-0874401349
Publisher: Samuel French, Inc.
Date (Month/Year): 978-0874401349

AWARD HISTORY

2003 National Qualifier

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